1. DATE - TIME GROUP 5 August 53 6/0345Z	**2. LOCATION** Rapid City, Blackhawk, South Dakota Area
3. SOURCE Civilian & Military	**10. CONCLUSION** [redacted] (Astro Aircraft) VISUAL: [redacted] RADAR: Anomalous Prop.
4. NUMBER OF OBJECTS Multiple	
5. LENGTH OF OBSERVATION Numerous	**11. BRIEF SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS** Numerous military & civilian observed an unusual red object which traveled in various direction in the general vicinity of Rapid City, S. D. Object was described as making various weird maneuvers. Objects were observed by numerous civilian and military. Jet intercepts were made and objects was tracked on radar. Another similar objects was observed later. Lighting includes data from Ellsworth and Ellsworth AFB. CONCLUSIONS: ATIC sent representative to investigate. was unable to determine the identity of object. Photos of radar also gun camera on a/c were taken but were no good because of careless discrepancies on the photographing of the object.
6. TYPE OF OBSERVATION (Radar, Air-Visual, Air-Intcp/Ground-Visual, Ground-)	
7. COURSE Not Reported	
8. PHOTOS ☒ Yes ☐ No	
9. PHYSICAL EVIDENCE ☐ Yes ☒ No	
5 Aug	N & S Dakota C-7

FORM FTD SEP 63 0-329 (TDE) Previous editions of this form may be used.

[redacted]

5 August 1953 Rapid City, South Dakota

Description

Since this sighting was a combined air-visual, ground-visual, air-radar, and ground-radar report, it was decided that Project Blue Book would send an investigator to the scene. The controller on duty at the time of the incident was interviewed. His account of the incident was almost identical to that given in the initial TWX. He was on duty at 2005 MST when a COC post observer called in an unidentified flying object sighted northeast of her post at Blackhawk, South Dakota. (Note: Sunset 1920 MST - Twilight 33 minutes.) She reported through the Rapid City Filter Center. She reported that the object was stationary, then moved south toward Rapid City. When the controller got the report that the object or light was headed toward Rapid City, he sent 3 airmen from the radar site to look for it visually. They reported a light moving from generally north to south at a high rate of speed. At this time the controller observed 2 blips going south on the scope. He could not get a distinct track because of ground clutter in the area. In a few minutes the GOC post in Blackhawk called in that the light was back in nearly its original position. An airborne F-84 was vectored into the area and after a search made visual contact. The F-84 was vectored into the blip that was remaining stationary at about 15 miles northeast of Blackhawk. The controller said that he believed the F-84 pilot saw the target that was on the scope. Shortly after the visual sighting by the pilot, the target started to move on a heading of about 320 degrees magnetic. Four good blips were obtained. Photos of this track were taken but the camera malfunctioned and the photos were no good. The last blip occurred at 70 miles and at that point the aircraft was returned to the base. The GOC observer reported seeing the aircraft and the object, and both were moving. The object seemed to be out-distancing the F-84. As soon as the F-84 landed, another F-84 took off for CAP. Just about that time, the Blackhawk GOC post called the third time stating that the object was back again. Nothing was on the scope (there was possibly a target in the ground clutter), so the F-84 was vectored in on the visual report. The pilot soon got a visual and started an intercept. About that time, the controller picked up both an unknown target and the F-84. Both were on a heading of about 360 degrees magnetic. The blip seemed to stay about 5-10 miles ahead of the F-84. The chase continued until the aircraft was about 80 miles out, then the intercept was broken off. The target continued off the scope. At this time the Bismarck Filter Center was alerted to look for unidentified flying objects. When the pilot got back over the base, he saw another light. This was not picked up on the scope, but the controller did get a return on the height finder equipment in the general direction of the light, it was 8000 feet. At 0023 MST, Bismarck began to call in reports.

The pilot who was on the first CAP was interviewed next. He stated that he had been making passes at a B-36 north of Rapid City when GCI called and said they had a target west of Rapid City. He searched for

[redacted]

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DOD DIR 5200.10

[redacted]

about 20 minutes west and south of Rapid City but saw nothing. He returned to base and was about to land when he observed a light northwest of the base. He started out on a heading of 350 degrees magnetic, the object was high (30 deg - 45 deg) at 11 o'clock from him. He checked the possibility of a reflection and determined that this was not the cause. He continued his course keeping the object at 11 o'clock for a better view. After about 30 seconds, it disappeared then reappeared for another 30 seconds at the end of which it abruptly faded and was not seen again. The object was silver in color and varied in intensity. It appeared to "pull away" because it got smaller. The comment as to size was that it was "brighter than the brightest star I've ever seen".

The pilot who flew the second CAP was interviewed next. He stated that he took off and started to climb when GCI told him that GOC had a light. He was north of Ellsworth AFB on a heading of 360 degrees magnetic when he saw a light 30-40 degrees to his right and level. He thought it was a star or planet but as he looked away it appeared to "jump" 15-20 degrees in elevation. (Note: Due to the speed of the aircraft and the fact that the pilot was intent on identifying the object, he was not exactly sure of his positions. All positions are subject to some error.) The light seemed to be parallelling his course. The first thing the pilot did was to check for reflections in the cockpit (i.e., canopy, gunsight head, etc.). He was sure the light was no reflection in the aircraft. The light, which the pilot estimated to be considerably brighter than a star, changed intensity and changed in color from white to green. When the object was first sighted, the aircraft was at 15,000 feet. The pilot started to climb and the light appeared to climb faster. This was because the angle of elevation increased. He climbed to 26,000 feet. All this time both the radar blip of both the object and the aircraft were being carried and the pilot was talking to the controller on UHF. As the pilot turned into the light on his initial sighting, he turned on his radar gunsight. As he swung onto the target, the warning light came on. No range was obtained since the sight starts to measure at about 4,000 yards. All this might indicate was that something was beyond 4,000 yards. The light remained on until the chase was broken off. After thechase, on the way home, the light blinked on and off several times indicating a possible malfunction. The sight was not checked by maintenance on return and had not been checked since.

The F-84 chased the light for about five minutes, or to about 80 miles north of the base. The light appeared to make slow changes in color and intensity. The pilot stated that the light definitely moved in relation to the stars. After the intercept was broken off, the aircraft returned toward base.

About 20 miles out of base he got a visual on a similar light that changed from red to white. He was on a heading of 180 degrees magnetic at 12-14,000 feet and the light was 10 degrees low to the right. He thought it was a car going around curves in the hills but changed his mind when the red and white lights were of equal intensity. This target was in the ground clutter of the radar but something at 8000 feet was picked up on the height finder radar. The light slowly went out then

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came back in. It seemed to be west moving since the aircraft was kept on a constant heading and the angle of azimuth and elevation increased. The light was first observed for 30 seconds, it faded, reappeared, then faded again after 30 seconds.

As the pilot came around the west side of the air base and up the east side, he saw another light and turned into it to take gun camera photos. (The photos were no good).

Discussion

A visit was made to the Weather Bureau station at the Rapid City Municipal Airport to check weather and balloon launches (Note: The air base launches no balloons). The observer on duty looked up the balloon track for the balloon launched at 2000 MST on 5 August 1953 and it went south from the Municipal Airport. This puts it out of the area of the sighting. Data on inversions was not available as it had been forwarded to Asheville, North Carolina. (Note: The balloon tracks and weather for 2000 MST on 5 August has been requested from Asheville.)

No attempt was made to contact the GOC observers at Blackhawk. They had been interrogated by base personnel and were "all excited". It was believed that an investigator talking to them would only further excite them needlessly. All the sightings at Bismarck are doubtful. The AC&W Station called the Bismarck Filter Center and told them to "look for flying saucers", a perfect set up to see every star move around.

The upper air research balloon tracks at Lowry were checked. Two balloons were lost and could have been in the area at the time of the sighting.

A few comments on the sources can be made:

Controller left the impression that he was trying to prove the existence of an unidentified flying object. It is very unfortunate that no scope photos were available to collaborate his story. He saw targets on the scope, there is no doubt about it, but whether they acted exactly as he stated is unknown.

The two airmen that went outside to observe the object that was being carried on radar and reported by the GOC were not sure of what they saw, at least this is the impression they left. They were told to go out and look for a light so they saw one. Their description fits that of a meteor. They only saw a "streak" in the sky. They did not see it return north, only go south.

The first pilot only got a glimpse of a light so he could not add much.

The second pilot gave the impression of being "on the ball". He obviously was trying to convince himself the light was a star, but was

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[redacted]

having difficulty. He took a realistic approach and had done some logical reasoning. He was worried about the fact that the light moved relative to the stars.

By eliminating doubtful sightings, the only thing that can be reasonably assured is that a GOC post observed a light. This could be a balloon or star. Radar picked up something in the general area of the GOC post and vectored an aircraft toward it. The pilot saw a light and chased it. He got a radar lock on it, but this could have been a malfunction. The star Capella is possibly visible low on the horizon to the north and the pilot could have seen this. Pending further study, this incident is carried as Unsolved.

Conclusion

Unsolved.

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740TH AIRCRAFT CONTROL AND WARNING SQUADRON
Ellsworth Air Force Base
South Dakota

19 January 1954

Dr. J. A. Hynek
Ohio State University
Columbus, Ohio

Dear Doctor:

After your departure I checked possibility that Lt. Needham was a man who tended to become excited or confused in emergencies. I discussed the possibility with several of his associates and particularly with his operations officer, Major Fairbrother. Contrary to Mr. [redacted]s statement, I found that Lt. Needham is a very reliable, cool individual with an excellent combat record. On the other hand, I also checked a little on Mr. [redacted] reliability. Some of the pilots of aircraft that he has controlled have termed [redacted] This happened before the incident in question and he has apparentlycalmed down somewhat since then as he grew more accustomed to his job. I also have had a report from my adjutant that Mr. [redacted] has been known to exaggerate stories. Those exaggerations were particularly noticed in Mr. [redacted]s recounting of past baseball records. It just so happened that the adjutant has been a student of baseball records for some years and he immediately detected the inaccuracy of the stories. He told no one about them at the time and did not contradict Mr. [redacted] on the spot because he wanted to avoid embarrassment for him. Apparently Mr. [redacted] will tell stories to improve his prestige although the facts may not be accurate. The adjutant and Mr. [redacted] were both members of the squadron baseball team during the past summer and the adjutant noted that Mr. [redacted] will never admit that he might have been wrong. He engaged in several serious arguments with umpires when it was apparent to everyone, including members of both teams, that he was wrong.

The above story leaves me somewhat embarrassed. There were three members of my organization who contributed to the authenticity of the incident. The two Staff [redacted] and [redacted]. [redacted] Although these facts do not entirely discredit their statements I do not feel [redacted] By adding Mr. [redacted] it appears the observations of all three can be treated skeptically. These military observers are of course the only people to whom I can ascribe traits of reliability. However, it would appear that a part of any future investigation could appropriately contain a reliability investigation of all persons who offer evidence of unusual sightings. I say this in spite of the fact that I agree with you that observers should not be automatically subjected to ridicule.

In my own mind I have now totally discounted the entire incident as an unfortunate series of seemingly coincident circumstances. A light was observed by a ground observer which could very well have been from a light aircraft. This sighting was reported to Mr. [redacted] as a flying saucer. Mr. [redacted] then interpreted a target on the scope as the object in question and sent an interceptor after it. He contrived a track which may well have been the track of his own interceptor and the "chase" was pursued to the north. The pilot was told that he was chasing a light and he picked out a handy one in accordance with the vector

that he was given from the ground station. Obviously the pilot would be serious at the time, particularly since he was told that there was a ground and a radar observation of the object. On reconsideration I believe he is willing to admit that he was chasing a large star. Considering the reliability of ~~Mx~~ the military witnesses at the radar site, the excitement of Mr. [redacted], and the relatively poor description of subsequent sightings in the Rapid City area, I feel that the incident can be discounted from consideration entirely. The sightings in the Bismarck area cannot be judged by me but the power of suggestion must be considered in these, particularly since a correlated story of sightings was passed from Rapid City to the North Dakota Filter Center. I can imagine the degree of credulity that could be lent to the story in the minds of Filter Center personnel when I realize that the statements in the official report from Rapid City were sufficient incentive for you and the people of ATIC to conduct an extensive investigation. Essentially the same information, possibly embellished, was relayed to North Dakota that same night and, to use your words, the people there "could not consider the incident in the cool light of morning."

My interpretation of the incident relegates me to the ranks of skeptics and certainly does not permit scientific conclusions as such. I do wonder if perhaps many of the twenty percent of unresolved cases might not respond to a psychiatric rather than a scientific approach. The persentage of unsolved cases might be reduced at least somewhat.

I have taken the liberty of inclosing an article which labels me as a devotee of Mr. Pearson amongst others. I passed it along in case you missed it, particularly since the tone was moderate. The article was in this evenings paper and it was most timely to me.

Trusting that you had apleasant and rapid trip home and that I may be of service to you again, I am,

Yours truly,

/s/ Allen L. Atwell
Major, USAF

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2 February 1954

Major Allen L. Atwell
Commander, 740th AC&W Squadron
Ellsworth Air Force Base
Rapid City, South Dakota

Dear Major:

Thank you for your letter of 19 January. You have been of considerable service to us in tracking this down further, and especially in giving us the highly important character sidelights. I think the "baseball" example is particularly telling. I therefore feel as you do, that the incident reports from Rapid City sprang from, in general, unreliable observers. Even the two lieutenants, under questioning, were not sure of what they saw, but at least they were honest enough to admit this.

I agree with your statement concerning reliability checks, and hasten to assure you that one of the reasons we came out in person was to size up the observers. Speaking for myself, although I think the Captain would concur, we are ready to write off the Rapid City--Black Hawk incident as "information from questionable sources." In short, we can't trust the evidence, and when this happens in any scientific procedure the thing to do is throw the whole thing out the window.

I would like to ask, just for possible future reference: with a good man at radar controls, what are the possibilities of "unknown blips" over a long period? That is, out of 365 days, would you say that unknowns appear on the scope several times each day? Once every few days? A few times a year? I am assuming blips not due to malfunction but to echos, etc.

What I now have to say will surprise you: The observers at Bismarck I would class as entirely reliable. It is therefore impossible for us to write off the Bismarck incident in a like manner. Indeed, I wish we could. It is impossible, however, to say that the objects seen in Bismarck were the result of suggestion from Rapid City, because at least two people independently (and 15 miles apart) reported the objects without pervious knowledge of the phone call from Rapid City. The objects persisted for more than two hours, and the various observers agreed, within reason, on their tracks.

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